Article

Ming Liu*

Recontextualizing the basic law in *South China morning post*: a diachronic corpus-assisted discourse study

https://doi.org/10.1515/ijld-2025-2014
Received February 10, 2025; accepted August 25, 2025; published online October 28, 2025

Abstract: The Basic Law serves as the foundation of Hong Kong's governance and its unique status under Chinese sovereignty, yet its interpretation and implementation have often sparked debate and controversy since the 1997 handover. This study conducts a corpus-assisted discourse analysis of the recontextualization of the Basic Law in the influential English-language newspaper, *South China Morning Post*, over a 25-year period (1997–2022). The aim is to uncover diachronic changes in how the Basic Law has been recontextualized by integrating text mining with critical discourse studies. The findings identify three distinct periods of recontextualization, each characterized by particular patterns and approaches. This study contributes to a deeper understanding of the Basic Law's recontextualization and highlights the benefits of combining text mining with critical discourse analysis.

Keywords: basic law; corpus-assisted discourse study; Hong Kong; *South China morning post*; news

1 Introduction

The Basic Law of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (HKSAR) serves as Hong Kong's constitutional framework, outlining its governance, legal system, and relationship with Mainland China under the "One Country, Two Systems" principle (Chen 2017). Enacted by the National People's Congress (NPC) of China in 1990 and implemented on July 1, 1997, following Hong Kong's handover from British to Chinese sovereignty, the Basic Law guarantees a high degree of autonomy for Hong Kong, except in matters of foreign affairs and defence (Liu 2021). As a constitutional document, the Basic Law is central to maintaining Hong Kong's unique status and

***Corresponding author: Ming Liu**, Department of Language Science and Technology, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University, Hong Kong, Hong Kong, E-mail: ming1.liu@polyu.edu.hk

balancing its integration with Mainland China while safeguarding its distinct systems and way of life. However, its interpretation and implementation have been points of contention, particularly regarding issues of autonomy, governance, and freedoms (Tu 2020).

Although media representations of Hong Kong have been extensively examined after Hong Kong's handover to reveal the dynamic relations between media and politics, most of these studies are event-based, such as Hong Kong's handover (Lee et al. 2002), the right-of-abode issue (Pan 2002), Chief Executive election (Zhang and Mihelj 2012), national education debate (Cheng and Ho 2014), the Umbrella Movement (Lee and Chan 2018), and the Anti-Extradition Bill protests (Liu and Ma 2022; Wang 2022). Some recent diachronic studies suggest that media representations of Hong Kong tend to vary with the changing socio-political contexts (Cheng and Lam 2010, 2013; Liu and Jiang 2019; Liu and Zhong 2020). While the Basic Law was frequently referenced in news media's coverage of Hong Kong, few studies gave an extensive examination of the representations of the Basic Law (Cheng 2019; Ng 2020). This study incorporates text mining into critical discourse studies to give a corpus-assisted discourse study of the Basic Law recontextualization in the *South China Morning Post* during the 25 years after Hong Kong's handover. It aims to answer two research questions: (1) How does the recontextualization of the Basic Law vary with different time periods? (2) What are the socio-political factors behind the variation in its recontextualization?

2 Critical discourse studies and recontextualization

Critical Discourse Studies (CDS) is an interdisciplinary approach that examines how language and communication reflect, reinforce, or challenge power, ideology, and social inequalities (Flowerdew and Richardson 2018). It views discourse as a social practice that shapes and is shaped by societal structures and emphasizes how language is used to legitimize authority, marginalize groups, and reproduce dominant ideologies (Wodak and Meyer 2016). It provides a valuable framework for legal discourse studies, because legal discourse, often presented as neutral and objective, serves as an important site of ideological struggles (Cheng and Machin 2023). By focusing on how laws and their interpretations are discursively constructed and represented in legal texts, political communication, and media, CDS sheds light on the ways law functions not as an impartial system but as a site of negotiation and contestation over power and meaning (Cheng et al. 2023).

The concept of recontextualization as a theoretical framework is often credited to Bernstein in his sociology of pedagogy (Bernstein 1990). It is now widely understood as the "dynamic transfer and transformation of something from one discourse or text-in-context (the context being, in reality, a matrix or field of contexts) to another" (Linell 1998: 144–145). In critical discourse analysis (CDA), this concept is significant for its focus on the dynamic nature of texts, highlighting how meaning is reshaped across contexts. Recontextualization is not a neutral process but rather "an act of control", subject to ongoing appropriation and manipulation (Wodak and Fairclough 2010). By emphasizing recontextualization, CDA reveals the dynamic processes of text production and the hegemonic struggles embedded within them (Fairclough 2003).

Recontextualization has been increasingly used in CDA studies on communication practices in different fields, such as education (Wodak and Fairclough 2010), political discourse (Erjavec and Volčič 2016), corporate and organizational discourse (Chouliaraki and Fairclough 2010), and news discourse (Daghigh and Amini 2022). They have demonstrated how different elements of texts can be recontextualized to serve a certain communicative purpose. For example, Liu and Lin (2021) examine the recontextualization of "One Country, Two Systems" in Chinese, British, and American newspapers. The findings show not only the systematic differences between Chinese and Anglo-American newspapers but also the subtle differences between American and British newspapers in their specific ways of recontextualization. These studies have shed light on the politics of recontextualization in media discourse.

Studies on recontextualization in legal discourse have also drawn growing interest, because the interpretations of legal discourse in different contexts have significant social and legal impacts (Boyd 2016; Cheng et al. 2023; Wodak and Fairclough 2010; Wu et al. 2016). Wodak and Fairclough (2010) examine the recontextualization of European higher education policies in Austria and Romania. Cheng et al. (2023) examine the recontextualization of the US use of extraterritorial or "long-term" law against China in the BBC. Ng (2020) also investigates the recontextualization of Beijing's interpretation of Article 104 of the Basic Law by different parties in Hong Kong in 2016. He demonstrates that Beijing's voice can be recontextualized by different parties to serve different political purposes.

Nevertheless, most of these studies rely on the qualitative examination of a small sample of texts to uncover the processes of recontextualization. Further research is needed on how to draw insights from the recent development in corpus linguistics (CL) and computational linguistics to propose new methods for an extensive examination of recontextualization in a large corpus (Liu and Lin 2021).

3 Corpus-assisted discourse studies

Corpus-assisted discourse studies (CADS) are known for their emphasis on the "balanced" combination or "synergy" of the methods and theories of CDS and CL (Baker et al. 2008). The primary aim is to contribute to the mutual development of both disciplines and to reveal insights that cannot be gained by subordinating the methods and theories of one discipline to those of the other (Baker and McEnery 2015). CADS argue for the necessity for the analyst to move constantly between the results generated by corpus-analytic tools and the detailed analysis of some linguistic patterns in their specific contexts of use in order to test prior assumptions and form new assumptions about the data. Equally informed by the methods and theories of CDA and CL, CADS seek to raise the most appropriate research questions and identify the most proper analytic methods for the data (Haarman and Lombardo 2009).

Since its very beginning, CADS have demonstrated a strong interest in media and political discourse analysis (Friginal and Hardy 2021; Kennedy 2022; Partington 2010; Song et al. 2021). However, CADS have been confronted with new challenges in their future development. On one hand, most CADS relied on traditional corpus linguistic methods, such as key words, concordances, and collocates (Baker 2006), but "there is a need for the development of text mining and visualization tools in order to provide researchers with manageable views of salient linguistic forms in large corpora" (Salway 2017: 167). On the other hand, CADS have recently been criticized for lacking identifiable and accountable methods in their qualitative analysis (Kennedy 2022). This suggests the need to draw insights from both disciplines and propose more innovative methods for balanced quantitative and qualitative analysis of large corpora (Liu 2024; Liu and Huang 2026 [In press]).

4 Data and methodology

4.1 Data collection and corpus building

This study focuses on the *South China Morning Post* (SCMP). It is a leading English-language quality newspaper based in Hong Kong, renowned for its in-depth reporting and analysis of news in Hong Kong, Mainland China, and the broader Asia-Pacific region (Cheng and Lam 2010). Established in 1903, the SCMP has long been recognized as one of Asia's most influential publications and particularly valued for its balanced reporting, investigative journalism, and expert commentary, maintaining its reputation as an authoritative voice in Hong Kong and beyond (Liu and Zhong 2020). This study focuses on the news reports on the Basic Law from 1 July 1997

to 30 June 2022. All the news texts are extracted from the electronic database LexisNexis year by year with the keyword search of "*basic law* AND *Hong Kong*", and they are further manually examined to guarantee that all the collected news texts are closely related to the Basic Law. Then, these news texts are put into an Excel file in a chronological order to build a diachronic corpus of the Basic Law, which can be readily imported into the text mining tool KH Coder.

4.2 Analytic methods and procedure

This study relies on the text mining tool KH Coder. The software KH Coder is used for computer-assisted quantitative content analysis and text mining (Higuchi 2016, 2017). KH Coder is an open source software, which uses "Standford POS Tagger to extract words from English data, R for statistical analysis, and MySQL to organize and retrieve data" (Higuchi 2016: 78). It can be used to perform different kinds of analyses, such as topic, modelling, correspondence analysis, co-occurrence network analysis, word association analysis, and multi-dimensional scaling.

With the help of KH Coder, this study starts with a correspondence analysis of the news texts in terms of the years. Correspondence analysis is a statistical technique used to identify relationships and patterns in categorical data, particularly text data. It is widely used for analyzing co-occurrence patterns in text mining, such as identifying how words, phrases, or categories are distributed across documents, groups, or contexts. KH Coder integrates correspondence analysis as one of its key tools for visualizing and exploring these relationships. It can visualize the distribution of the prominent words across the 25 years and help identify those years which show similar patterns. It can contribute to an automatic classification of these texts into different periods based on the results of correspondence analysis (Liu and Huang 2026 [In press]).

Word association analysis in KH Coder is a text mining technique used to explore the relationships between words or terms in a dataset. It examines how frequently specific words co-occur and identifies patterns of association, helping users uncover hidden connections, themes, or structures in large text datasets. It can be used to examine these words that co-occur with *Basic Law* in each period and visualize the results in terms of different clusters. Besides, it can also rank these strong co-occurring words in terms of their log-likelihood values. A further examination of these strong co-occurring words can further help reveal the different ways of constructing the Basic Law.

This study first examines the co-occurrence network of words that tend to co-occur frequently with *Basic Law* in a sentence. It can cluster these prominent words into different groups and visualize them in different colours for each period. These

different clusters can suggest the different themes associated with *Basic Law* in a sentence. It is followed by a separate examination of the top 10 verbs and adverbs that have a strong tendency to co-occur with *Basic Law*. They suggest the particular ways of constructing the Basic Law in each period.

Together, these methods enable the analysis of the recontextualization of the Basic Law at multiple levels of discourse. On the macro-level, correspondence analysis reveals overarching themes and shifts in discourse over time, linking them to broader socio-political developments. On the micro-level, word association analysis captures the specific linguistic constructions of the Basic Law, providing insights into how it is framed, contested, and utilized in news discourse. This dual-level analysis is particularly valuable in CDS, as it combines quantitative precision with qualitative depth, allowing for a comprehensive exploration of how the Basic Law is situated within shifting power dynamics and ideological struggles (Partington 2010).

5 Findings

5.1 Correspondence analysis

Figure 1 shows the result of the correspondence analysis. As Figure 1 shows, these texts can be generally classified into three periods: (1) **Period I** (1997–2003); (2) **Period II** (2003–2015); and (3) **Period III** (2016–2022). **Period I** consists of such words as *SAR*, *abode*, *Appeal*, *ruling*, *JUSTICE*, *child*, *right*, *court*, *COURT*, *case*, *bill*, *legislation*, *MR*, *TUNG*, *legislator*. These words reflect Hong Kong's early years under Chinese sovereignty following the 1997 handover. This period was characterized by efforts to establish governance under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework and to navigate legal and constitutional challenges. Key words such as *SAR* (Special Administrative Region), *TUNG* (Tung Chee-hwa, Hong Kong's first Chief Executive), and *legislator* highlight the focus on institution-building and governance during this era. As a newly established SAR, Hong Kong was tasked with implementing the Basic Law, which served as the territory's constitutional framework, while balancing its autonomy with Beijing's sovereignty. Legal and judicial themes also dominate this period, reflected in words like *court*, *ruling*, *JUSTICE*, *case*, *interpretation*, *Bill*, and *legislation*. These words highlight the critical role of the judiciary in interpreting and applying the Basic Law, particularly in cases related to autonomy, human rights, and governance. Significant legal disputes, such as the right of abode cases, tested the limits of Hong Kong's autonomy and Beijing's authority. The word *NPC* (National People's Congress) refers to Beijing's legislative body, which issued interpretations of the Basic Law during this time. Social issues are also reflected in terms like *child* and *abode*, which point to the right of abode controversy. This legal battle centered on

whether children of Hong Kong residents born in Mainland China had the right to live in the city, sparking debates about immigration, family rights, and the interpretation of the Basic Law. The term *right* underscores the broader focus on protecting freedoms and rights guaranteed under the Basic Law, as Hong Kong worked to establish itself as a society governed by the rule of law. Therefore, **Period I** features a period of adjustment and foundation-setting. Hong Kong's government, led by Tung Chee-hwa, focused on legislative and judicial processes to implement the Basic Law, address key social issues, and define the city's role under Chinese sovereignty. These early years were crucial in shaping the institutional and legal frameworks that would guide Hong Kong in the years to come, while also setting the stage for future tensions between autonomy and integration with the Chinese mainland.

Period II consists of such words as *democracy*, *universal*, *suffrage*, *reform*, *TSANG*, *chief* [Noun], *executive*, *pan-democrat*, *committee*, *candidate*, *proposal,* and *central*. These words suggest that **Period II** represents a time of heightened political debate, public activism, and focuses on democratic reform in Hong Kong. Terms like *democracy*, *suffrage*, *universal*, and *reform* emphasize the growing demand for

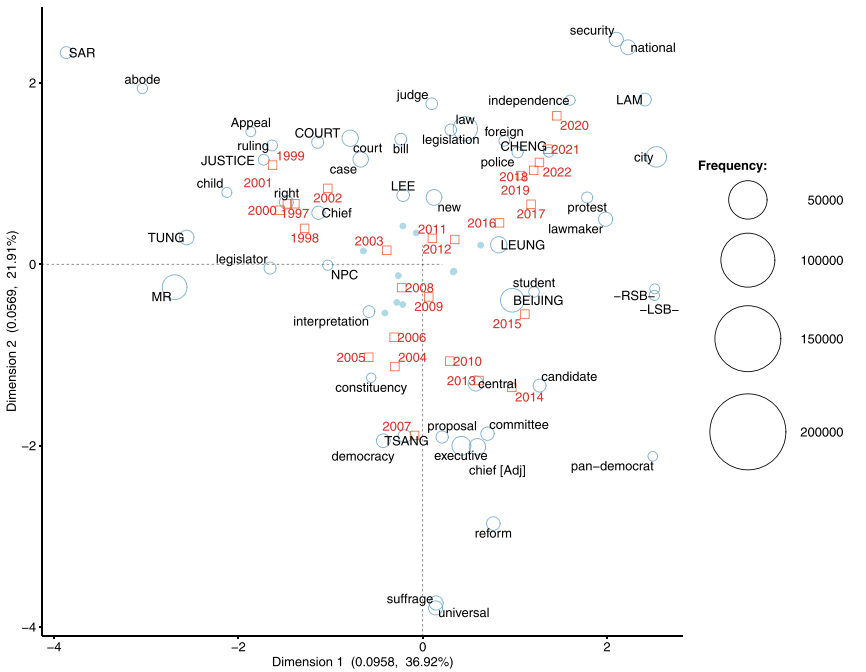


Figure 1: Correspondence analysis (1997–2022).

universal suffrage in the election of the Chief Executive and Legislative Council, which became a central political issue during this era. The word *proposal* highlights the various political reform packages introduced during this period, many of which faced fierce public and legislative opposition. Terms like *executive*, *committee*, and *candidate* point to key debates about the structure and nomination process for the Chief Executive, particularly Beijing's influence over the system through the Election Committee. This tension was further underscored by the term *central*, which refers to the Central Government in Beijing and its role in shaping the direction of Hong Kong's political reforms. The word *TSANG* reflects the influence of Donald Tsang, who served as Chief Executive from 2005 to 2012, during pivotal discussions about governance and reform. Additionally, *pan-democrat* refers to the pro-democracy camp, which played a significant role in advocating for electoral reforms and opposing Beijing's restrictive proposals. This period also saw increasing public engagement, as reflected by terms like *student*, which ties to the rise of student-led activism, culminating in the 2014 Umbrella Movement. Therefore, these words highlight a period of intense political tension and focus on democracy, electoral reform, and governance. This era was marked by a significant evolution in Hong Kong's political identity and its relationship with the Basic Law.

Period III consists of such words as *national*, *security*, *independence*, *protest*, *police*, *law*, *foreign*, *city*, *Lam*, *Cheng*, and *lawmaker*. The words suggest a period defined by political unrest, national security concerns, and significant changes in governance in Hong Kong. Terms like *security* and *national* reflect the growing emphasis on sovereignty-related issues, particularly after the enactment of the National Security Law in 2020. The word *independence* reflects ongoing conflicts and discussions surrounding Hong Kong's autonomy, with some activists advocating for independence from Chinese oversight. Similarly, *protest* captures the widespread anti-government demonstrations, such as the 2019 Anti-Extradition Law Movement, which mobilized millions of residents and drew global attention. Words like *police* highlight the role of law enforcement during these protests, often marked by clashes between demonstrators and police, as well as accusations of excessive force. The inclusion of *foreign* suggests concerns over international involvement, as the Chinese government frequently accused foreign governments of interfering in Hong Kong's affairs. Key figures like *LAM* (Carrie Lam, Chief Executive from 2017 to 2022) and *CHENG* (Teresa Cheng, Secretary for Justice) appear prominently, reflecting their central roles during this tumultuous period. The term *lawmaker* underscores the changing political dynamics within Hong Kong's Legislative Council, particularly after the electoral reforms imposed by Beijing in 2021, which ensured that only *patriots* could hold office.

5.2 Co-occurrence network analysis

Figure 2 shows the co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* during **Period I** (1997–2003). There are altogether 6 clusters. **Cluster 1** focuses on the central government's role in shaping and interpreting the Basic Law, particularly through the NPC Standing Committee. A prominent issue during this period was the right of abode disputes. **Cluster 2** focuses on the administrative and legislative mechanisms of the Hong Kong SAR government, as well as the contributions of prominent figures like Maria Tam Wai-chu and Jasper Tsang Yok-sing (Hung-yee) in shaping the Basic Law's implementation. **Cluster 3** emphasizes the Basic Law's promise to safeguard fundamental rights and freedoms under the "One Country, Two Systems" principle. **Cluster 4** highlights the debates and controversies surrounding Article 23 of the Basic Law, which mandated Hong Kong to enact laws prohibiting acts like treason, subversion, and secession. The government's attempt to pass national security legislation in 2003 faced widespread public opposition, as many feared it would erode freedoms and autonomy. **Cluster 5** focuses on the Basic Law's provisions for democratic development, particularly the ultimate goal of achieving universal suffrage for the election of the Chief Executive and Legislative Council. During this period, demands for greater democratic reforms grew, but progress remained gradual and contentious. **Cluster 6** addresses the Sino-British Joint Declaration, which laid the foundation for the Basic Law and Hong Kong's governance under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework. Therefore, the six clusters in Figure 2 reveal the multifaceted role of the Basic Law during its early implementation from 1997 to 2002. Overall, these clusters reflect the dynamic interplay between Hong Kong's autonomy, Beijing's authority, and the Basic Law's role in navigating this balance.

Figure 3 shows the co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* (2004–2015). There are all together 10 clusters. **Cluster 1** reflects the central government's role in interpreting and enforcing the Basic Law, particularly through the NPC Standing Committee. The term *interpretation* underscores the importance of the NPC's power to issue binding interpretations of the Basic Law, often shaping governance issues in Hong Kong. It emphasizes the ongoing tension between Hong Kong's autonomy and Beijing's control. **Cluster 2** focuses on the individuals involved in drafting the Basic Law, particularly mainland Chinese legal experts such as Xiao Weiyun and Han Dayuan Chongde, who played key roles in shaping the document. **Cluster 3** concerns disputes over residency rights and the judicial interpretation of the Basic Law. The right of abode cases, which began in the late 1990s and continued to influence discussions during this period, reflect the tension between Hong Kong's judiciary and Beijing's authority. **Cluster 4** highlights the long-standing debates over democratic reform and the promise of universal suffrage for electing the Chief Executive and

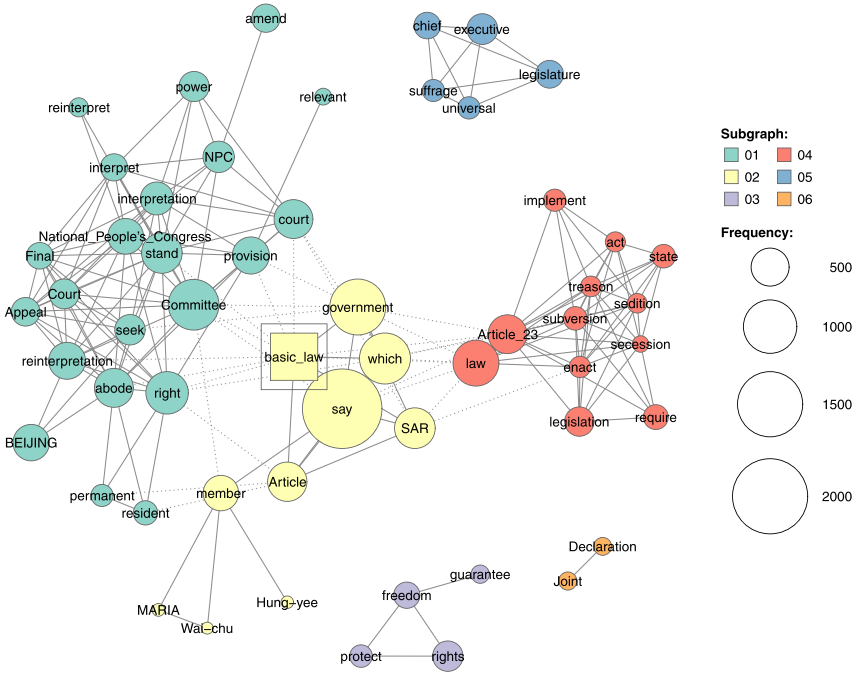


Figure 2: Co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* (1997–2003).

Legislative Council. The phrase "*One Country, Two Systems*" reflects the political framework that guarantees Hong Kong's autonomy. Words like *gradual* and *orderly* point to Beijing's emphasis on a controlled pace for democratic development, while *universal suffrage* underscores the aspirations for greater electoral rights. **Cluster 5** points to the role of legal experts in interpreting the Basic Law and advising on its implementation. Legal scholars and practitioners were instrumental in addressing complex constitutional issues, such as residency rights, electoral reforms, and national security, which often required nuanced legal analysis. **Cluster 6** pertains to the Chief Executive's role and terms of office under the Basic Law. The selection and governance of the Chief Executive were key topics of discussion during this period, with debates focusing on the electoral process and the balance of power between the executive and legislative branches. **Cluster 7** reflects concerns over the protection of rights and freedoms under the Basic Law. The term *violate* highlights perceived infringements on civil liberties, while *Bill* and *Rights* refer to legal and political efforts to protect these freedoms. **Cluster 8** focuses on the electoral process and representation in accordance with the Basic Law. The term *nominating* committee was central to debates about the selection of Chief Executive candidates, particularly

during the 2014 electoral reform proposals. The terms *procedure* and *broadly* representative refer to the Basic Law's requirements for democratic development, which were contested by pro-democracy activists and Beijing. **Cluster 9** reflects the contentious efforts to legislate national security provisions under Article 23 of the Basic Law. Although initial attempts to pass this legislation in 2003 failed due to public protests, national security remained a significant issue during this period. **Cluster 10** refer to Elsie Leung Oi-sie, a key figure in the implementation of the Basic Law and the first Secretary for Justice of Hong Kong. As vice-chairwoman of the NPC Standing Committee's Basic Law Committee, she played a significant role in advocating Beijing's interpretations of the Basic Law. Together, they illustrate the evolving challenges and debates over Hong Kong's autonomy, governance, and integration with China under the Basic Law.

Figure 4 shows the top 200 co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* (2016–2022). **Cluster 1** highlights the Basic Law's role as Hong Kong's mini-constitution, governing its legal framework under the "One Country, Two Systems" principle. Words like *Annex*, *III*, and *insert* refer to the constitutional provisions that allow for amendments and the addition of national laws into Annex III of the Basic Law. **Cluster 2** emphasizes the Basic Law's guarantee of fundamental rights and freedoms under the "One

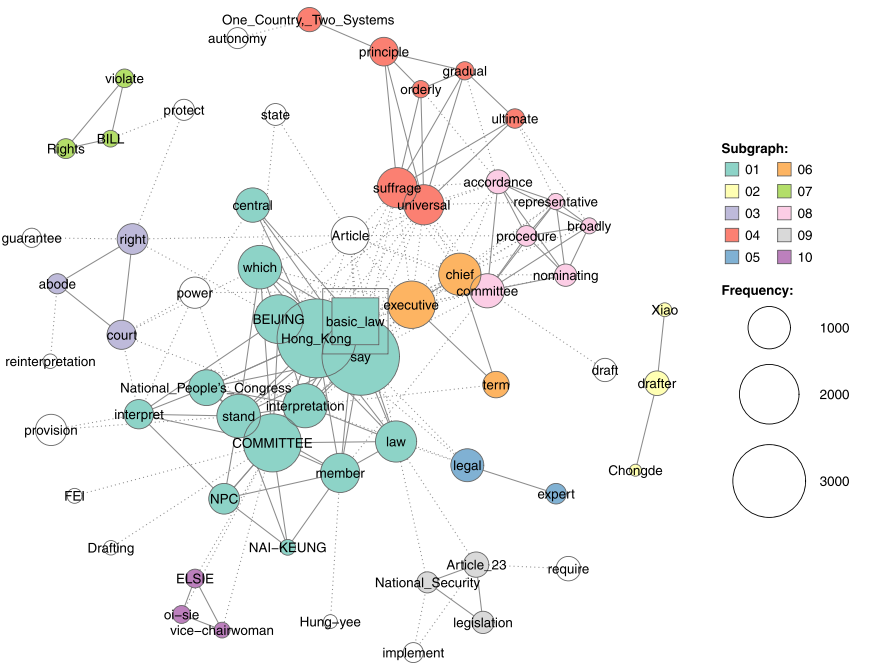


Figure 3: Co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* (2004–2015).

Country, Two Systems" framework. It also reflects the tension between protecting these rights and perceived violations, with words like *violate* and *argue* highlighting debates and disputes over their enforcement. The inclusion of terms like *enshrine* and *autonomy* points to the foundational promise of the Basic Law to preserve Hong Kong's distinct legal, political, and social systems for 50 years after the handover. **Cluster 3** refers to the Sino-British Joint Declaration, the international treaty that laid the foundation for the Basic Law and guaranteed Hong Kong's autonomy and freedoms after the 1997 handover. The inclusion of *breach* suggests concerns or accusations of violations of the Joint Declaration, particularly in relation to actions by Beijing that were perceived as undermining Hong Kong's autonomy. **Cluster 4** focuses on the Basic Law's provisions for maintaining allegiance to the Hong Kong SAR and the People's Republic of China. Words like *pledge* and *swear* highlight the requirement for public officials to uphold the Basic Law and swear allegiance to the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region. The inclusion of *inalienable* reflects the Basic Law's assertion that Hong Kong is an inalienable part of China, reinforcing the sovereignty of the central government. **Cluster 5** represents key figures involved in the drafting and implementation of the Basic Law. Individuals like *Geping* (Xu Jiatun, a representative of Beijing) and *Albert Hung-yee* (Jasper Tsang Yok-sing) played significant roles in shaping the Basic Law and representing the central government's perspectives. **Cluster 6** reflects the central government's authority to interpret the Basic Law through the NPCSC. The NPCSC's interpretations have often been controversial, particularly when they are perceived as overriding Hong Kong's judiciary or limiting its autonomy. **Cluster 7** refers to prominent individuals such as Maria Tam Wai-chu and Elsie Leung Oi-sie, who played central roles in advising on and implementing the Basic Law. Both were members of the NPC Standing Committee's Basic Law Committee and were instrumental in promoting Beijing's interpretations of the Basic Law. **Cluster 8** pertains to the controversial Article 23 of the Basic Law, which requires Hong Kong to pass legislation to prohibit acts of treason, sedition, and subversion. The failed attempt to enact Article 23 in 2003 due to widespread public protests is a central theme of this cluster. It also reflects ongoing debates about balancing national security with the protection of freedoms and autonomy. Together, these clusters highlight the evolving challenges and debates over Hong Kong's autonomy, the implementation of the Basic Law, and the balance between local governance and central control.

The themes across the three periods provide a nuanced picture of the evolving political landscape in Hong Kong. Key issues like national security legislation, the role of Beijing (through the NPCSC), civil rights and freedoms, and the Sino-British Joint Declaration remained central throughout all three periods, indicating the ongoing tension between Hong Kong's promised autonomy and Beijing's growing influence over its governance, legal system, and freedoms. These recurring themes thus reflect the broader struggle related to the Basic Law.

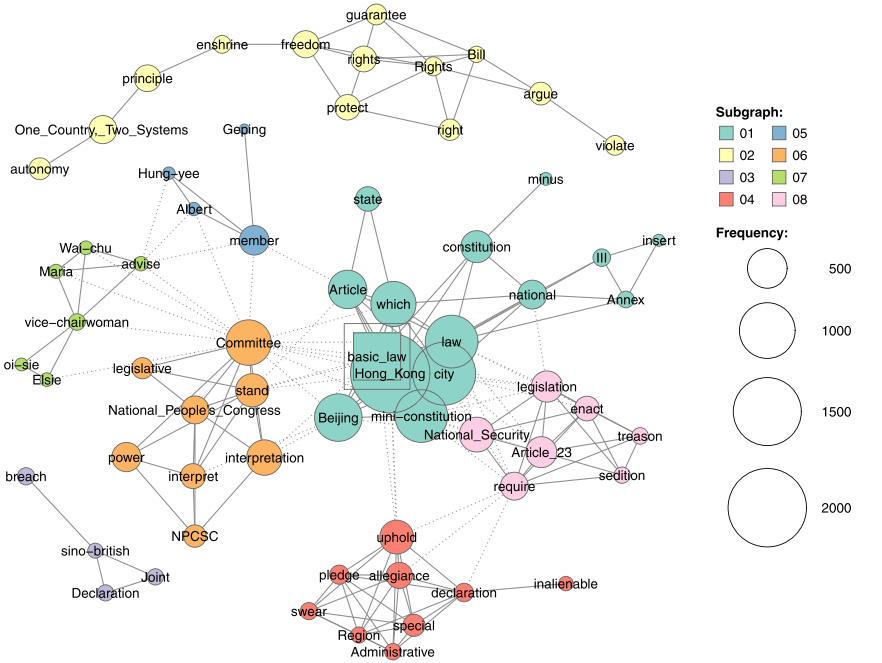


Figure 4: Top 200 co-occurrence network of *Basic Law* (2016–2022).

Each period, however, reveals distinct themes and characteristics that reflect the evolving political landscape. In **Period I**, disputes over the right of abode and interpretations of the Basic Law emerged as central issues. By **Period II**, the focus shifted to civil rights and universal suffrage. In **Period III**, the legislation of Article 23 and the assertion of the authority of the became the dominant concerns. Thus, the three periods illustrate a progression from an emphasis on civil rights to local autonomy, and ultimately to the central government's growing authority over Hong Kong.

5.3 Analysis of strong co-occurring words of *basic law* in each period

5.3.1 Analysis of strong co-occurring verbs of *basic law*

Table 1 shows the top 10 strong co-occurring verbs of *Basic Law* in a sentence in the corpus. These verbs provide insights into the changing priorities in interpreting, applying, and enforcing the Basic Law over time.

Table 1: Top 20 strong co-occurring verbs of *basic law*.

Rank	1997–2003			2004–2015			2016–2022		
	Word	**Conditional**	**LL**	**Word**	**Conditional**	**LL**	**Word**	**Conditional**	**LL**
1	*Stand*	572	914.8	*Interpret*	543	1,550.6	*Uphold*	430	837.6
2	*Amend*	272	734.5	*Stand*	1,213	1,228.1	*Enact*	362	730.2
3	*Interpret*	251	703.7	*Say*	4,938	992.2	*Enforce*	252	649.6
4	*Breach*	207	595.7	*Amend*	402	866.3	*Interpret*	233	447.9
5	*Reinterpret*	120	496.5	*Draft*	327	758.5	*Apply*	336	379.9
6	*Contravene*	107	401.0	*Stipulate*	254	704.9	*Stand*	523	362.2
7	*Stipulate*	118	368.1	*Enshrine*	185	619.7	*State*	271	355.2
8	*Say*	2,241	354.2	*Breach*	237	610.4	*Protect*	316	352.3
9	*Require*	208	296.0	*Enact*	224	579.0	*Require*	362	342.7
10	*Seek*	317	293.4	*State*	344	537.6	*Violate*	199	329.9

The verbs in **Period I** suggest the foundational role of the Basic Law, as it was actively interpreted and debated following Hong Kong's return to China in 1997. Key verbs like *stand* and *require* emphasize the basic law's significance as the legal cornerstone of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region. These verbs reflect its role in delineating obligations and governance structures. Verbs such as *interpret* and *reinterpret* highlight the need to clarify the Basic Law's provisions, especially as ambiguities arose in its early implementation. This was particularly evident in residency disputes (e.g., the right of abode cases), where judicial interpretation played a central role in determining compliance with the Basic Law. Additional verbs like *amend* and *stipulate* suggest efforts to refine the Basic Law's application and address gaps in its provisions. The presence of *contravene* and *breach* indicates concerns about ensuring compliance, as stakeholders debated and addressed potential violations. The frequent use of *seek* and *say* reflects the active discussions and legal challenges during this formative period, as various parties sought clarity and consensus on how the Basic Law should guide Hong Kong's governance. Therefore, **Period I** is characterized by defining the Basic Law's role, resolving ambiguities, and establishing its authority as a legal framework.

The verbs in **Period II** shift toward addressing legal disputes, interpretation, and refinement of the Basic Law as it encounters challenges in its application. The most prominent verb *interpret* underscores the frequent need to clarify the Basic Law's provisions in response to political and legal debates. This is particularly relevant to controversies such as universal suffrage and the interpretation of executive powers. Verbs like *draft* and *amend* reflect efforts to refine the Basic Law and propose adjustments or supplementary legislation to address evolving circumstances. These processes aim to adapt the Basic Law to the realities of governance and align it with Beijing's expectations, while still addressing local concerns in Hong Kong. The use of *say* and *state* signifies the role of public and political discourse in referencing and debating specific provisions of the Basic Law, as well as concerns about compliance and breaches. Verbs like *enshrine* highlight the emphasis on formalizing rights and principles guaranteed under the Basic Law, while *enact* reflects discussions about implementing laws and policies within its framework. *Breach* and *stipulate* continued to highlight concerns about compliance and the legal requirements embedded in the Basic Law. This period reflects a more dynamic interplay between interpretation, refinement, and debates over the Basic Law's application.

Period III marks a shift toward enforcement, compliance, and protection of the Basic Law, reflecting heightened political and social tensions in Hong Kong. This period saw the adoption of new measures to ensure adherence to the Basic Law, as well as efforts to safeguard its authority amidst growing challenges to governance and autonomy. New verbs like *uphold*, *enact*, and *enforce* dominate this period, signalling a focus on implementing and ensuring compliance with the Basic Law's

provisions. These verbs reflect the central government's push to solidify the Basic Law's authority, particularly in the wake of events like the 2014 Umbrella Movement and the 2019 anti-extradition bill protests. Although *interpret* remains relevant, its declining frequency compared to earlier periods suggests a shift in focus from interpreting the Basic Law to enforcing its provisions. Similarly, *stand* and *state* continue to be significant, reinforcing the Basic Law's foundational role and its explicit directives. Verbs like *protect* and *violate* reflect the polarized discourse surrounding the Basic Law in this period. On one hand, there is a focus on safeguarding the Basic Law, particularly in relation to national security and governance. On the other hand, concerns about violations highlight the contentious nature of political developments during this time. The prominence of *apply* and *require* reflects the practical implementation of the Basic Law in legal and governance contexts.

The evolving usage of strong co-occurring verbs with the Basic Law demonstrates a clear progression in its role over time. In **Period I**, the focus was on clarifying and defining the Basic Law's provisions. In **Period II**, attention shifted to resolving legal disputes and refining its application. By **Period III**, the emphasis was on enforcement and protection, reflecting a response to rising political and social challenges. These trends underscore the dynamic nature of the Basic Law's interpretation and application, as well as its central role in shaping Hong Kong's governance and autonomy under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework.

5.3.2 Analysis of strong co-occurring adverbs of *basic law*

As Table 2 shows, the shifts in the use of adverbs reflect changes in priorities, from clarity and strict adherence to broader interpretations and enforcement, as the political and legal environment of Hong Kong transformed over time.

During **Period I**, the discourse focused on clarity, strict adherence, and establishing the Basic Law as a legal cornerstone in post-handover Hong Kong. Adverbs such as *clearly*, *strictly*, *directly*, *specifically*, *resolutely*, and *fully* dominate the discussions, reflecting efforts to ensure that the Basic Law is understood, respected, and implemented as intended. The prominence of *clearly* emphasizes the explicitness of the Basic Law's principles, ensuring that its provisions are unambiguous and authoritative. Similarly, *strictly* and *specifically* highlight the importance of adhering to the exact terms of the Basic Law to establish its credibility and legal authority. Adverbs like *directly* and *expressly* underscore the directness of the Basic Law in addressing governance issues, while *resolutely* and *fully* reflect the determination of stakeholders to enforce the Basic Law completely and without compromise. This period was characterized by a commitment to clarity and precision as Hong Kong transitioned to governance under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework.

Table 2: Top 10 strong co-occurring adjectives of *basic law*.

Rank	1997–2003			2004–2015			2016–2022		
	Word	**Freq.**	**LL**	**Word**	**Freq.**	**LL**	**Word**	**Freq.**	**LL**
1	*Clearly*	74	55.1	*Broadly*	131	305.4	*Clearly*	64	69.1
2	*Not*	1,260	33.5	*Strictly*	49	117.1	*Not*	910	57.9
3	*Constitutionally*	14	27.9	*Clearly*	138	99.3	*As*	127	31.7
4	*Directly*	63	26.4	*Also*	682	80	*Constitutionally*	17	31.5
5	*Expressly*	11	22.3	*Explicitly*	20	39.1	*Well*	117	30.5
6	*Strictly*	16	19.8	*Correctly*	20	33.8	*Genuinely*	18	30.4
7	*Resolutely*	6	19.7	*Only*	437	29.9	*Accurately*	19	29
8	*Specifically*	15	17.8	*Not*	2011	28.5	*Fully*	42	28.3
9	*Fully*	39	17.6	*Specifically*	24	26.5	*Effectively*	40	26.5
10	*Also*	340	16.7	*Expressly*	11	25.3	*Sincerely*	19	21.3

In **Period II**, the discourse shifts toward broader interpretations, legal disputes, and political debates about the Basic Law. Adverbs such as *broadly*, *explicitly*, *strictly*, and *correctly* become more prominent, reflecting the complexities of applying the Basic Law to evolving circumstances. The adverb *broadly* emphasizes the wide-ranging applicability of the Basic Law's provisions and its relevance to diverse legal and governance challenges, while *explicitly* highlights the need to stress specific guarantees and obligations outlined in the document. Although *clearly* remains relevant, its declining prominence compared to the earlier period indicates a shift toward broader and more nuanced interpretations. The rise of *correctly* suggests increasing concerns about potential misinterpretations of the Basic Law, underscoring the need to ensure accurate application. Additionally, adverbs like *also* and *only* reflected the evolving discussions around specific aspects or limitations of the Basic Law's scope. This period marked a transition from clarity to broader interpretations, as legal and political challenges to the Basic Law became more frequent.

By **Period III**, the discourse focuses on enforcement, compliance, and the protection of the Basic Law amidst escalating political tensions in Hong Kong. Adverbs such as *effectively*, *fully*, *genuinely*, *accurately*, and *sincerely* gained prominence, reflecting a shift in focus toward ensuring adherence to the Basic Law's authority. The adverbs *effectively* and *fully* highlight the need for proper and complete enforcement of the Basic Law, especially in response to challenges to its governance framework. Meanwhile, terms like *genuinely*, *accurately*, and *sincerely* emphasize the importance of authentic and faithful adherence to the Basic Law's principles, signalling concerns about whether its application aligns with its intended purpose. The continued use of *clearly* indicates a persistent need for clarity in interpreting the Basic Law, even as the focus shifts to enforcement. The prioritization of protection during this period reflects the central government's efforts to safeguard the Basic Law amidst political and social unrest, such as the 2019 anti-extradition bill protests and the implementation of the National Security Law in 2020.

In summary, the evolution of co-occurring adverbs with the Basic Law across these three periods illustrates the shifting priorities in Hong Kong's legal and political discourse. **Period I** prioritized clarity and strict adherence to establish the Basic Law's authority. **Period II** focused on broader interpretations and legal disputes as challenges to the Basic Law's provisions emerged. **Period III** emphasized enforcement, compliance, and protection, reflecting the growing need to safeguard the Basic Law amidst rising tensions. These shifts mirror the broader political and social changes in Hong Kong, highlighting the dynamic role of the Basic Law in navigating the complexities of governance under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework.

6 Discussion and conclusion

This study has revealed three distinct periods in the recontextualization of the Basic Law in the newspaper. The analysis of changes in the discourse surrounding the Basic Law across the three periods reflects Hong Kong's evolving socio-political landscape under the "One Country, Two Systems" framework. These shifts highlight the transition from Hong Kong's initial post-handover adjustment to a period of rising political tensions and democratic aspirations, culminating in the central government's consolidation of its authority over Hong Kong.

During **Period I**, the discourse emphasized clarity, strict adherence, and the foundational role of the Basic Law. This was a period of adjustment and institution-building as Hong Kong transitioned into a Special Administrative Region (SAR) under Chinese sovereignty (Flowerdew 2004). The judiciary played a central role during this time, particularly in cases such as the right of abode disputes, which tested the limits of Hong Kong's autonomy while exposing tensions with Beijing's authority.

Period II marked a shift toward political tension, public activism, and demands for democratic reforms. This period was defined by debates about universal suffrage for the Chief Executive and Legislative Council, which culminated in the 2014 Umbrella Movement. The NPC Standing Committee (NPCSC) played a more assertive role in shaping Hong Kong's political and legal landscape, often clashing with pro-democracy advocates. This period represented a turning point in Hong Kong's political identity, featuring a growing emphasis on local autonomy rather than national integration (Liu 2022).

By **Period III**, the discourse had shifted decisively toward enforcement, compliance, and consolidation of the Basic Law. This era was shaped by escalating political tensions, widespread protests, and the enactment of significant legal changes such as the National Security Law (2020). The 2019 Anti-Extradition Bill protests marked a fundamental transformation, as the central government strengthens its authority over Hong Kong. The 2021 electoral reforms, which ensured that only patriots could hold public office, further paved the way for Hong Kong's future political development.

The evolution of discourse across these three periods reflects the changing priorities and socio-political realities of Hong Kong under the Basic Law. In the early years, the focus was on clarifying and establishing the Basic Law's authority, while democratic aspirations and legal disputes became central in the mid-period. By the most recent period, the emphasis had shifted to enforcement and protection, driven by Beijing's desire to assert greater authority over Hong Kong amidst growing political unrest. The Basic Law has thus become a site of contestation, reflecting the broader struggle between local aspirations and central authority.

This study has demonstrated the advantages of incorporating text mining techniques into critical discourse studies, particularly when analysing evolving legal and political discourses like those surrounding the Basic Law (Liu 2024; Liu and Huang 2026 [In press]). By employing methods such as correspondence analysis and word association analysis, the study has been able to systematically uncover patterns, themes, and shifts in discourse across different time periods, providing a robust framework for exploring the recontextualization of the Basic Law. By uncovering both broad patterns and specific linguistic constructions, this approach enhances our understanding of the evolving role of the Basic Law in Hong Kong's socio-political landscape, shedding light on its recontextualization across different historical and political contexts.

Research funding: This work was supported by General Research Fund of the Research Grants Council of Hong Kong (15618225).

References

Baker, Paul. 2006. *Using corpora in discourse analysis*. London and New York: Continuum.

Baker, Paul & Tony McEnery (eds.). 2015. *Corpora and discourse studies: Integrating discourse and corpora*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Baker, Paul, Costas Gabrielatos, Majid Khosravinik, Michał Krzyżanowski, Tony McEnery & Wodak Ruth. 2008. A useful methodological synergy? Combining critical discourse analysis and corpus linguistics to examine discourses of refugees and asylum seekers in the UK press. *Discourse and Society* 19(3). 273–306.

Bernstein, Basil. 1990. *Class, codes and control: The structuring of pedagogic discourse*. London: Routledge.

Boyd, Michael S. 2016. From news to comment: Tracing text trajectories in news reporting about the Amanda Knox trial. In Lieve Gies & Maria Bortoluzzi (eds.), *Transmedia crime stories*, 139–164. Leicester: Palgrave Macmillan.

Chen, Albert H. Y. 2017. The Hong Kong basic law and the limits of democratization under "One Country Two Systems". *The International Lawyer* 50. 69–85.

Cheng, Winnie. 2019. The rule of law and the threat of civil disobedience in Hong Kong: Metaphorical structures in local media coverage. *The Linguistics Journal* 13(1). 173–196.

Cheng, Winnie & Janet Ho. 2014. Brainwashing or nurturing positive values: Competing voices in Hong Kong's national education debate. *Journal of Pragmatics* 74. 1–14.

Cheng, Winnie & Phoenix Lam. 2010. Media discourses in Hong Kong: Change in representation of human rights. *Text and Talk* 30(5). 507–527.

Cheng, Winnie & Phoenix Lam. 2013. Western perceptions of Hong Kong ten years on: A corpus-driven critical discourse study. *Applied Linguistics* 34(2). 173–190.

Cheng, Le & David Machin. 2023. The law and critical discourse studies. *Critical Discourse Studies* 20(3). 243–255.

Cheng, Le, Xiaobin Zhu & David Machin. 2023. The depoliticization of law in the news: BBC reporting on US use of extraterritorial or 'long-arm' law against China. *Critical Discourse Studies* 20(3). 306–319.

Chouliaraki, Lilie & Norman Fairclough. 2010. Critical discourse analysis in organizational studies: Towards an integrationist methodology. *Journal of Management Studies* 47(6). 1213–1218.
Daghigh, Ali Jalalian & Alireza Amini. 2022. Ideological manipulation in political news translation: An actor-network perspective. *Journalism* 23(7). 1530–1547.
Erjavec, Karmen & Zala Volčič. 2016. The Kosovo battle: Media's recontextualization of the Serbian nationalistic discourses. *Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics* 12(3). 67–86.
Fairclough, Norman. 2003. *Analysing discourse: Textual analysis for social research*. London: Routledge.
Flowerdew, John. 2004. Identity politics and Hong Kong's return to Chinese sovereignty: Analysing the discourse of Hong Kong's first chief executive. *Journal of Pragmatics* 36(9). 1551–1578.
Flowerdew, John & John E. Richardson (eds.). 2018. *The routledge handbook of critical discourse analysis*. New York: Routledge.
Friginal, Eric & Jack A. Hardy (eds.). 2021. *The routledge handbook of corpus approaches to discourse analysis*. London: Routledge.
Haarman, Louann & Linda Lombardo (eds.). 2009. *Evaluation and stance in war news*. London: Continuum.
Higuchi, Koichi. 2016. A two-step approach to quantitative content analysis: KH Coder tutorial using Anne of green gables (part I). *Ritsumeikan Social Science Review* 52(3). 77–91.
Higuchi, Koichi. 2017. A two-step approach to quantitative content analysis: KH Coder tutorial using Anne of green gables (part II). *Ritsumeikan Social Science Review* 53. 137–147.
Kennedy, Charlotte-Rose. 2022. Worthiness, unity, numbers and commitment: Strengthening qualitative corpus methods in the critical discourse analysis of protest press coverage. *Discourse and Society* 33(5). 611–630.
Lee, Francis L. F. & Joseph M. Chan. 2018. *Media and protest logics in the digital era: The umbrella movement in Hong Kong*. New York: Oxford University Press.
Lee, Chin-Chuan, Joseph Man Chan, Zhongdong Pan & Y. K. So Clement. 2002. *Global media spectacle: News war over Hong Kong*. Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press.
Linell, Per. 1998. Discourse across boundaries: On recontextualizations and the blending of voices in professional discourse. *Text* 18(2). 143–158.
Liu, Ming. 2021. One city, two stories: Competing discursive constructions of postcolonial Hong Kong in Chinese and American newspapers. In Josef Schmied, Chenguang Chang & Matthias Hofmann (eds.), *Working with discourses: Corpus and systemic functional perspectives*, 143–160. Göttingen: Cuvillier Verlag.
Liu, Ming. 2022. Stancetaking in Hong Kong political discourse: A corpus-assisted discourse study. *Chinese Language and Discourse* 13(1). 79–98.
Liu, Ming. 2024. Towards a 'synergy' of text mining and critical discourse analysis: A corpus-assisted discourse study of imagining China in Hong Kong political discourse. *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 39(2). 625–637.
Liu, Ming & Jingyi Huang. 2026. Incorporating text mining into critical discourse studies: A corpus-assisted discourse study of press representations of climate change in China. In Bernhard Forchtner & Franco Zappettini (eds.), *Handbook on britical discourse studies*. London: Edward Elgar [In press].
Liu, Ming & Cong Jiang. 2019. Constant fear, but lingering nostalgia: British press representations of post-colonial Hong Kong 20 years on. *Discourse and Communication* 13(6). 630–646.
Liu, Ming & Ling Lin. 2021. "One country, two systems": A corpus-assisted discourse analysis of the politics of recontextualization in British, American and Chinese newspapers. *Critical Arts* 35(3). 17–34.
Liu, Ming & Jingxue Ma. 2022. The politics of fear in Hong Kong protest representations: A corpus-assisted discourse study. *Journal of Language and Politics* 21(1). 37–59.
Liu, Ming & Jiali Zhong. 2020. Between national and local: Identity representations of post-colonial Hong Kong in a local English newspaper. *Discourse, Context and Media* 36. 100401.

Ng, Toby Wing-Chun. 2020. Recontextualisation of Beijing's voice: A critical discourse analysis of hegemony and resistance in Hong Kong political discourse. *Discourse and Society* 31(5). 540–561.
Pan, Xiaping. 2002. Consensus behind disputes: A critical discourse analysis of the media coverage of the right-of-abode issue in postcolonial Hong Kong. *Media, Culture and Society* 24(1). 49–67.
Partington, Alan. 2010. Modern diachronic corpus-assisted discourse studies (MD-CADS) on UK newspapers: An overview of the project. *Corpora* 5(2). 83–108.
Salway, Andrew. 2017. Data-driven approaches to climate change discourse, illustrated through case studies of blogs and international climate negotiation. In Kjersti Flottum (ed.), *The role of language in the climate change debate*, 151–170. New York and London: Routledge.
Song, Yunya, Zeping Huang, Jonathon P. Schuldt & Y. Connie Yuan. 2021. National prisms of a global phenomenon: A comparative study of press coverage of climate change in the US, UK and China. *Journalism* 23(10). 2208–2229.
Tu, Yunxin. 2020. The question of 2047: Constitutional fate of "One Country, Two Systems" in Hong Kong. *German Law Journal* 21(8). 1481–1525.
Wang, Guofeng. 2022. Britain as a protector, a mediator or an onlooker?: Examining the 2019–20 Hong Kong protests in British newspapers. *Journal of Language and Politics* 21(1). 17–36.
Wodak, Ruth & Norman Fairclough. 2010. Recontextualizing European higher education policies: The cases of Austria and Romania. *Critical Discourse Studies* 7(1). 19–40.
Wodak, Ruth & Michael Meyer (eds.). 2016. *Methods of critical discourse analysis*. London: Sage.
Wu, Jianguo, Shanshan Huang & Rong Zheng. 2016. Recontextualization and transformation in media discourse: An analysis of the first-instance judgment of the Peng Yu case. *Discourse and Society* 27(4). 441–466.
Zhang, Mengmeng & Sabina Mihelj. 2012. Hong Kong identity and the press-politics dynamics: A corpus-assisted discourse study. *Asian Journal of Communication* 22(5). 506–527.

Bionote

Ming Liu
Department of Language Science and Technology, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University, Hong Kong, Hong Kong
ming1.liu@polyu.edu.hk

Ming Liu is an assistant professor at Department of Language Science and Technology, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. His research interests cover critical discourse analysis, corpus linguistics, pragmatics, systemic functional linguistics, and intercultural communication. His recent publications have appeared in some international journals, such as *Discourse & Society, Discourse & Communication, Language & Communication, Journal of Language and Politics, Text & Talk, Discourse, Context & Media, Lingua and Digital Scholarship in the Humanities*.